STATEMENT OF THE HONORABLE RICHARD C. HOLBROOKE, VICE CHAIRMAN, PERSEUS LLC (FORMER UNITED STATES AMBASSADOR TO THE UNITED NATIONS)

Ambassador Holbrooke. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. It is a great honor to appear before your committee. Before I begin testimony, with your permission I would just like to acknowledge the fact that Tom Lantos passed away a few weeks ago. He was a very dear friend of mine personally. I think he was a great chairman and a great American. I know you have honored him in magnificent ways here in the Capitol, but I just wanted to echo my own personal sense of loss and admiration.

And I might just add, that in the last talk I had with him 2 weeks, less than 2 weeks before he died, knowing his situation he went out of his way to talk about how important this committee would be and how, what other confidence he had with the personal leadership that you would exhibit, as well as you, Congresswoman. And that was the bulk of our last conversation. And I just wanted to say that.

You have called a hearing this morning on what I would submit is the second most urgent problem facing the next President of the United States after Iraq, and one that will go on far, far longer than the war in Iraq. I am not talking about Pakistan, Mr. Chairman, I am talking about what I would call theater AFPAK, the Afghan-Pakistan theater of operations. Important though Pakistan is in its own right, the comments that you and your colleagues have just made made clear why we are here today: It is because of Afghanistan. And there is no success possible in Afghanistan as long as Pakistan's tribal areas are a sanctuary for the Taliban and al-Qaeda, and a threat to the United States' national security continues to grow.

All of the comments that you and your colleagues have just made, the GAO report, the terrific report that General Jones and Ambassador Pickring put out, my own observations on my trip last month to Pakistan and Afghanistan, all support the same general concept: This war in Afghanistan is stalemated at best and, at worst, we may be losing ground in some areas. But yet the administration denies that fact in almost every way.

The last time the three of us sat at a table together was on the Senate side a few weeks ago. And after General and Assistant Secretary of State for this region was asked specifically whether he agreed with the conclusions of the Jones-Pickering report, which were that Afghanistan was not yet a failed state but was a failing state, the Assistant Secretary of State for the region flatly said no, said that he could not imagine—these are direct, accurate paraphrases—he could not imagine that anyone could not see how much better things were in Afghanistan. And he left your colleagues on the Senate side somewhat flummoxed. My own trip does not support his conclusions.

I want to address very, very quickly three issues: One, domestic situation in Pakistan; two, the tribal areas; and three, the Afghanistan.

On the first issue I agree completely with what you and Congressman Ackerman have just said. I think the only—that the best thing that has happened in Pakistan in a long time was this election. The situation is better in Pakistan today domestically than it has been in recent memory. President Musharraf is still President of the country but he has essentially been reduced to the constitutional powers of a chief of state, not a head of government, when he was forced to take off his uniform. General Kiani has made clear that he wants to keep the military out of politics. It is indispensable that take place. Nonetheless, there are many people

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